

S. RAMAKRISHNA
KARUTURI

43, EXPORTER
MD, KARUTURI GLOBAL
INITIAL INVESTMENT IN 1996 Rs 1.14 lakh
CURRENT TURNOVER Rs 400 crore

FLOWER POWER

With its latest acquisition—Sher Agencies, Kenya, in the last financial year—Karuturi Global Limited (KGL) became the first fully integrated Indian MNC in the field of agriculture. Taking the world's largest producer and exporter of cut roses towards an even rosier future is its managing director, Sai Ramakrishna Karuturi, 43. The story goes that in 1995 he was looking to buy flowers for his wife on Valentine's Day and found an acute shortage of good roses in Bangalore. This was when he decided to get into the business himself. "I was influenced by management guru Michael Porter's model of sustainable competitive advantage," says Karuturi of his journey on the flower carpet. "I identified high value horticulture as an area with immense potential." With rose farms on 298 hectares (not including 40 hectares in India under contract farming) spread over India, Kenya and Ethiopia, Karuturi is a globetrotting flower merchant. His global empire of roses started "with a shoestring budget, out of a room in my flat. But those were great days," he reminisces. What started with 3.2 hectares on the outskirts of Bangalore, today has operations spread across three countries and marketing offices in Dubai and The Netherlands.

Schooled at the Sri Rama Krishna Vidyashala, Mysore, followed by post-graduation from Bangalore University, Karuturi got his MBA from the Case Western Reserve University where he made it to the Dean's Honour's List. He came back to take over his family business of cables and transmission towers. Wife Anita is the finance director of KGL and the couple has three daughters. He lives in Bangalore and is "at home by 7 p.m. to spend time with the family as I consider that very important," says Karuturi, whose non-flower interests include reading fiction, watching films and going to the gym.

He cherishes two moments: "When I



success MANTRA

Never faced an obstacle. The big challenge is your own imagination.

role MODEL

Ratan Tata for daring to dream of the Indica and now the Nano

greatest MOMENT

When he brought a chartered 757 to Bangalore in 2000 to export his roses

brought a chartered 757 to Bangalore in 2000 to export the roses and, in 2007, when we became the world's largest rose company." He opened the first rose boutique at the Bangalore International Airport last year and expects to start 100 similar boutiques over the next two years. Expansion plans include production of gherkins as well as farming corn, palm oil, rice, vegetables and sugarcane on the recently acquired three lakh hectares of land and increasing staff strength from the current 10,000 to 50,000 employees by the turn of the decade. But as of now, the mainstay of the business continues to be roses with a target to reach one billion stems by 2010. No wonder, Karuturi still sends roses to people. Can't think of a better gift. *by Nirmala Ravindran*